objective fastest and with the least casualties. It would be a cardinal mistake to select an obvious option even if it's the best, as the adversary would be prepared for it. In fact, an objective analysis of the Second World War will reveal that the Allies suffered very heavy casualties while trying to land on the best beaches in Normandy. This was because the Germans were also expecting that and logically defending them in strength. I have laid great emphasis on encouragement of all ranks to *think and be original*, as I realized many officers and soldiers only did what they were told. They seldom used their mind. I would pull their legs and say, 'Are you guys preserving your brains for the next life!' In my career I took many innovative steps to inculcate this habit amongst all ranks of the army and used to give great incentives for original and creative ideas, innovations and inventions. As the chief, I also started a 'dreamers club' wherein anyone could email his or her idea to my office, which would then be passed on to the appropriate branch or directorate of the Army HQ. This initiative was hugely welcomed and a lot of ideas came in. Those which merited action were progressed. For example, we implemented one such idea of providing air-conditioned buses for conveyance from the residential areas to the Army HQ. This may not be of much significance to the advanced countries, where air-conditioned transport would be the norm, but in the Indian armed forces, air-conditioned buses were unheard of till 2005! So this step was greatly appreciated by the army. However, the dreamers club was a concept ahead of its time and did add on to the workload of the military bureaucracy. It wasn't followed up as enthusiastically as I expected. I hope it would get a new life in due course – when its time comes.

It is my belief that many military leaders don't really understand the essence of the phrase 'esprit de corps', or if they do, they do not practise the building up of such a spirit in their units or formations. For me it has been a magical phrase and I found its motivational and inspirational effect as a real force multiplier during my life. It helped me produce better results than others and run a happier team – the latter being very important to me. That is how I consistently overperformed even when I had been dealt a bad hand.